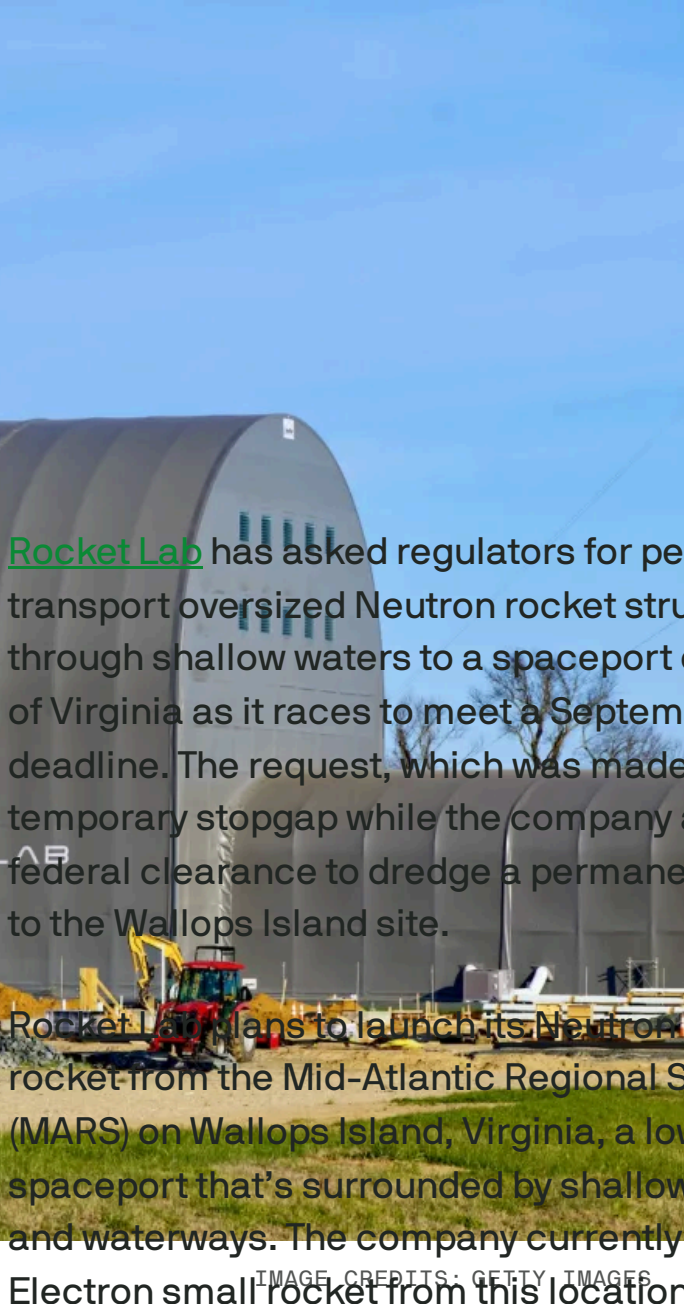


Advertisement

SPACE



**Rocket Lab's first hurdle
to flying its new rocket is
getting it to the pad**



[Rocket Lab](#) has asked regulators for permission to transport oversized Neutron rocket structures through shallow waters to a spaceport off the coast of Virginia as it races to meet a September delivery deadline. The request, which was made in July, is a temporary stopgap while the company awaits federal clearance to dredge a permanent channel to the Wallops Island site.

Rocket Lab plans to launch its Neutron medium-lift rocket from the Mid-Atlantic Regional Spaceport (MARS) on Wallops Island, Virginia, a lower-traffic spaceport that's surrounded by shallow channels and waterways. The company currently launches its Electron small rocket from this location.

IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

Rocket Lab has a sizable checklist to tick off before Neutron can make its orbital debut, like mating the rocket stages, performing a “wet dress” rehearsal, and getting its launch license from the Federal Aviation Administration.

Before any of that can happen, the rocket hardware needs to make it onto the island.

Rocket Lab submitted an application for the dredging project to the Virginia Marine Resources Commission in March. In its application, the company touted the benefits of MARS, noting other launch facilities in Florida and elsewhere are highly congested, which could limit launch cadence. MARS, in contrast, “will allow both frequent launch

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

cadence and the return-to-Earth capability of recovering boosters,” Rocket Lab said at the time.

Despite that upside, MARS is constrained in a crucial way: Existing maritime infrastructure is limited, and access to the channel — called Sloop Gut — depends on favorable tides.

As Rocket Lab and its co-applicant, Virginia Port Authority, notes in its request, “there is no permanent existing means of providing safe and reliable access for large infrastructure deliveries to Wallops Island.” (Electron is substantially smaller and delivered via road.)

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

TC

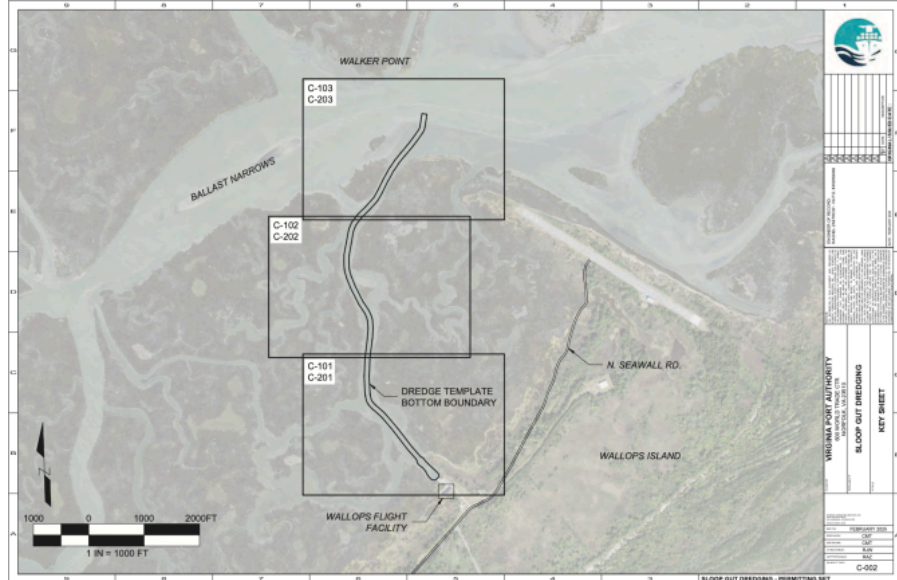
Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

Rocket Lab has poured millions into the MARS site to ensure it’s ready to support regular Neutron launches. The company is planning to spend more than \$5 million to dredge the roughly mile-long Sloop Gut so barges can perform regular deliveries of large Neutron rocket components.



ROCKET LAB'S PLANS TO DREDGE SLOOP GUT.

IMAGE CREDITS:ROCKET LAB

The dredging project was approved by VMRC in May, but the company has yet to start digging because it's still awaiting federal sign-off from the Army Corps of Engineers.

As the company waits for federal approval, Rocket Lab and VPA are seeking permission to use a temporary method called “kedging” to ensure the first five hardware deliveries can arrive on schedule starting in September.

The company has said it plans to launch Neutron's maiden test mission in the second half of 2025. But the dredging application and Rocket Lab's separate dredging request suggest that it's not hardware delays but maritime access that could be a bottleneck for the first launch.

Kedging, a little-known nautical method, is used to ensure the barges can safely navigate the existing shallow channel. Workers would use a series of anchors and lines to steer the barge through the shallow waters. The company is seeking permission to use this method through the end of June 2026 or until the dredging work is complete, whichever comes first.

It's unclear how long the dredging project will take. In the case that the keding request is not approved in a timely manner, Rocket Lab said in its application that it would be able to transport structures over the beach using ramps and cranes. The company received permission for up to three beach barge landing test events — but these cannot take place between March 15 and August 31, so it is far from a long-term solution.

In the dredging application, the company detailed several other alternative methods to get hardware on the island, like transporting it by road or public boat ramp. However, these methods were ultimately deemed infeasible for reasons such as cost, infrastructure limitations, and the weather.

Rocket Lab did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment. Both filings highlight the importance of maritime access for Rocket Lab's Virginia ambitions.

The sooner the company can start dropping kedge anchors in time to receive the hardware shipments, the sooner it can start knocking off the rest of its pre-flight checklist.

Topics: [neutron](#) [Rocket Lab](#) [Space](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [📷](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Aria Alamalhodaei

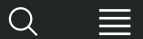
Reporter, Space and Defense | [X](#)

Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

[View Bio](#) >



Latest Security
Startups AI
Venture Apps
Apple



Events
Podcasts
Newsletters



Aria Alamalhodaei — 1:23 PM PST · November 25, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS: [ROCKET LAB](#)

[Rocket Lab](#) set a new speed record for launch turnaround time, successfully executing two Electron missions in 24 hours.

The company added in a statement that this is also the first time any launch operator has completed a mission from each hemisphere within that time frame.

Rocket Lab, which was founded in New Zealand, maintains a launch pad there and at the Mid-Atlantic Regional Spaceport in Virginia. The company has cited its ability to launch from pads in the U.S. and New Zealand as a competitive

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

advantage; when the Virginia pad became operational in 2022, [Rocket Lab CEO Peter Beck said](#) it enabled customers to “enjoy unmatched control over their launch schedule and orbital requirements.”

Those precise orbital insertions include access to polar and sun-synchronous orbits from the launch site in New Zealand, and to mid-inclination orbits from Virginia. Rocket Lab also operates a suborbital version of Electron, called Hypersonic Accelerator Suborbital Test Electron (HASTE) from the American launch pad. HASTE is used as a testbed for hypersonics and suborbital technologies.

These most recent launches included a HASTE suborbital launch from Virginia for an unnamed customer, and the launch of a pair of satellites from the French company Kinéis from Mahia Peninsula, New Zealand.

The company has completed 14 launches so far this year, but there likely won’t be too many more. In its most recent earnings announcement, Rocket Lab estimated it would launch the rocket 15 to 18 times in 2024. While Rocket Lab is best known for operating the small Electron rocket, which is second only to SpaceX’s Falcon 9 in terms of activity, the majority of the company’s revenue actually comes from its Space Systems business, which includes spacecraft design and manufacturing and the sale of satellite components. Of the \$105 million in revenues the company earned in the third quarter of this year, for example, \$21 million came from launch services and \$84 million from the Space Systems segment.

That proportion could change slightly when Rocket Lab brings its medium-lift rocket, Neutron, online mid-next year. The company currently estimates

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



launching that rocket once in 2025, three times in 2026, and five times in 2027.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Topics: [Rocket Lab](#) [Space](#)



Aria Alamalhodaei

Reporter, Space and Defense |

Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING



SPACE



Watch Rocket Lab launch Electron from US soil for the first time

Aria Alamalhodaei — 8:29 AM PST · January 24, 2023

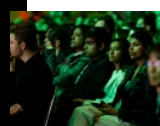
IMAGE CREDITS: [ROCKET LAB](#)



Latest in Space

See More

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

TechCrunch Events
- 20 hours ago

After multiple delays due to inclement weather and high winds, Rocket Lab is poised to launch its first mission from Virginia today, with a two-hour launch window opening at 6 p.m. EST.

The mission is called “Virginia is for Launch Lovers,” and the name is appropriate in more ways than one. Rocket Lab’s Electron rocket will carry a trio of spacecraft to low Earth orbit for HawkEye 360, a Virginia-based company that collects and analyzes radio frequency analytics using its own satellite constellation. The launch is part of a three-mission contract HawkEye signed with Rocket Lab last April.

It’s launch day pic.twitter.com/4O6JkWaliN

— Rocket Lab (@RocketLab) [January 24, 2023](#)

The rocket, which will take off from NASA’s Wallops Flight Facility, is also a first for the space agency: Electron is equipped with novel flight safety software that NASA directors say could be a game-changer for launch. The software is called the NASA Autonomous Flight Termination Unit (NAFTU), a key component of Rocket Lab’s Pegasus software, which was jointly developed by the rocket company and the space agency.

“This flight just doesn’t symbolize another launch pad for Rocket Lab,” CEO Peter Beck told reporters in a media briefing in December. “It’s a standing up of a new capability for the nation.”

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025

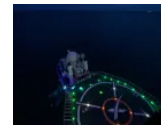


Only 2 days left to save \$675 on your TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket

TechCrunch Events

- 2 days ago

SPACE



SpaceX faces two new lawsuits alleging safety-related retaliation

Aria Alamalhodaie

- Jul 30, 2025

TC

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the

insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Rocket Lab has invested a significant amount of capital into its Virginia facilities. Beyond LC-2, as the launch complex is called, the company has also made Wallops the home of its Neutron rocket development. That includes [a launch site and manufacturing and refurbishing facility](#). Rocket Lab stands out amongst launch companies, including SpaceX, Relativity Space and Blue Origin, for choosing Virginia over NASA's Kennedy Space Center and the U.S. Space Force's Cape Canaveral in Florida. Beck cited "the quietness of the range" and the ability to increase launch cadence as the main draws over the Florida sites.

"KSC is an amazing range but I think everybody has to agree, it's pretty busy," he said. "The [Wallops] range is not nearly as busy and there's a lot of room to grow."

Once Rocket Lab has its livestream going, we'll post it to the top of the page. (*Update: it's live!*) You can also follow all the action over on the company's [Youtube channel](#).

Topics: [Electron](#) [NASA](#) [peter beck](#) [Rocket Lab](#)

[Space](#)

Advertisement



Aria Alamalhodaei

Reporter, Space and Defense | X

Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article



[TechCrunch](#)
[Staff](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Advertise](#)

[Crunchboard](#)
[Jobs](#)

[Site Map](#)

[Terms of](#)
[Service](#)

[Privacy](#)
[Policy](#)

[RSS Terms of](#)
[Use](#)

[OpenAI](#)
[Perplexity](#)
[Cisco](#)
[DeepMind](#)
[Windsurf](#)
[Tech Layoffs](#)
[ChatGPT](#)